

121 Identify types of trees

30
MINS

There are thousands of different trees in the world, but you can identify the ones in your yard by looking for “marker clues” like a detective. Note them down and consult a guide, and it will tell you what your tree is.

What you need

- Notebook and pen or pencil
- Tree guide—either in book form or online

1 First, look at the leaves. Are they long, thin leaves or wider, flat leaves with veins? Trees with needlelike leaves are conifers—evergreens that keep their leaves all year round. Trees with broad, flatter leaves are deciduous—most lose their leaves in the fall.



BROAD



CONICAL

2 Conifers like pines have sharp, needlelike leaves, but a cedar has flatter ones. The leaves of deciduous trees can have an alternating or opposite pattern, with one simple leaf or several small leaves on a single stem.



COLUMNAR



SPREADING

3 Look at the tree's bark—is it smooth or rough? Brown or silver? What about shape—is the tree tall and pointed or does it cast a wide, rounded shadow? Does it have fruit or cones?



NARROW



GNARLED

122 Play a game of Pooh sticks

5
MINS



Take two sticks, tie grass to one to help identify it, and drop both into flowing water on one side of a bridge. Cross to the other side of the bridge and see which stick comes out first.

Watch the sticks pass by